Spot the Misleading Chart

Student worksheet · Intermediate level

Name:	Class:	Date:

Every chart tells a story. A good chart tells a **true** story you can see at a glance. Use this sheet with the *Good Charts vs Bad Charts* website, set to the same level.

Part 1: Match each mistake to its rule

Write the letter of the rule that fixes each mistake.

Mistake	Letter	Rule
1. Bar chart axis starting above zero		**A.** Space dates by how much time really passed.
2. Two y-axes stretched to match		**B.** Show the trend, not the noise.
3. Joining every weekly result with a line		**C.** Bar charts always start at zero.
4. Color suggesting a group that isn't there		**D.** Up on the chart should mean more.
5. Pie chart with nine slices		**E.** To compare more than a few things, use sorted bars.
6. Upside-down y-axis		**F.** Show each period, not the total so far.
7. Running total hiding a drop		**G.** A new color should mean a new group.
8. Uneven gaps between dates		**H.** Be suspicious when two lines match perfectly.

Part 2: Take the quiz

Do the quiz on the website. Write your score, then the rule you found hardest and why.

My score:	out of 8
Hardest rule and why:	

Part 3: Find a chart in the real world

Find a chart in a news site, social media post, ad or textbook. Answer the questions below.

Where I found it (website, link or page):
What do I notice? What jumps out first?
What do I wonder? What questions do I have? What's missing?
The chart's headline: What story is it trying to tell, in one sentence?

Now check: is the story true?

Question	What I noticed
Where does the axis start? Bars should start at zero, or their lengths lie.	
Is there more than one axis? Two axes can be stretched to make any two lines look connected.	
What do the colors mean? A new color should mean a new group, nothing else.	
Is it a real change or just noise? Bumpy data needs a trend line, not a zig-zag.	
Is it easy to read? If it takes more than a few seconds to find the answer, the chart is in the way.	

Verdict (tick one): [ ] Good chart [ ] Confusing [ ] Hides the point [ ] Misleading
My honest headline:
How would you fix it? Sketch a better version.